

Section B: News

This section consists of:

- an **in-depth study** of **online** news, including its social and participatory media
- a study of historical and contemporary **newspaper** front covers to illustrate how media language is used to construct representations and to give an understanding of the contemporary newspaper industry.

Learners are required to study the following media products set by OCR:

Media Forms	Online, social and participatory media	Newspapers
Set Media Products	<i>The Observer Online</i> www.observer.co.uk including the use of social and participatory media	<i>Observer front covers</i> Two contemporary front covers and three historical front covers
Media Language	✓	✓
Media Representations	✓	✓
Media Industries	✓	✓
Media Audiences	✓	
Contexts	Social, Cultural, Political	Social, Cultural, Political and Historical

Online, social and participatory media (in-depth study)

The online, social and participatory set media product, *The Observer* allows for exploration of the importance of digital content to news organisations, and the ways in which this is used to monetise online content and engage audiences.

Learners must study the online, social and participatory media set products in relation to **all** four areas of the media theoretical framework, including **all** relevant theoretical approaches and social, cultural and political contexts.

Media Form	Set Product	Guidance on selection of set products
Online	<i>The Observer</i> online webpages www.observer.co.uk	Learners must study the home page of <i>The Observer</i> website and at least one other page in order to investigate continuities in the form and content of the pages. They must follow the links for a number of articles and journalists to help illustrate the media language used, representations constructed, modes of audience address and the scope and scale of <i>The Observer's</i> online content.
Social and participatory media	<i>The Observer</i> X feed (formerly Twitter) https://x.com/observer <i>The Observer</i> Instagram feed https://www.instagram.com/theobserveruk/	A consideration of how <i>The Observer</i> is featured in each of the social and participatory media feeds, including which articles are featured and a consideration of how media language and representations are used in comparison to the related online web articles.

NB: All set products selected for study in this section must be from the September onwards of the first year of teaching a two-year course. For example, from September 2017 onwards for a candidate entering for assessment in June 2019.

It is advised that teachers may wish to access the content of these webpages and any other social and participatory media sources in a controlled environment in order to ensure that learners do not access any inappropriate content.

The following indicative list is given as guidance and is not exhaustive. For example, in relation to **all** four areas of the media theoretical framework learners must consider:

- the impact of production processes and technologies on online newspapers and their social and participatory feeds
- how *The Observer* is owned and funded as a media institution and how funding issues have affected the drive to online media
- the convergent nature of media industries across different platforms
- the challenges for media regulation presented by online newspapers and social and participatory feeds
- how online content can be aimed at a range of audiences and more specifically targeted by media organisations
- how online audiences are categorised, including how readership and consumption is measured and how audiences are identified
- how audiences may interpret the same content very differently on different platforms (e.g. online webpage, X (formerly Twitter) quote or Instagram feed) and how these differences may reflect both social and individual differences
- the various forms of media language used to create and communicate meaning across online, social and participatory news media
- how selection, combination and exclusion of elements of media language can influence meaning in online, social and participatory news media
- the relationship between technology and the media language of online, social and participatory news

- the ways in which online, social and participatory news media re-present the world
- how the purposes of media producers and the choices they make influence representations
- the social, cultural and political significance of particular representations featured on online, social and participatory media in terms of the themes or issues they address.

Newspapers

The Observer has had considerable cultural and social impact and reach. *The Observer* has consistently had a large circulation and is a powerful voice within the centre-left media with significant cultural and social influence. The historical *Observer* newspaper covers were chosen to help learners gain a knowledge and understanding of how media language was used to construct representations in the 1960s and the contexts that affected those representations.

Learners must study:

- **three** set historical front covers of *The Observer* (the historical front covers will be made available via the OCR website)
 - *The Observer* 30 October 1966

- *The Observer* 6 November 1966
- *The Observer* 20 October 1968

- **two** contemporary front covers selected by the centre.

Learners must study the contexts associated with the set covers and develop an understanding of the differences between how these media products illuminate the changing social, cultural, historical and political contexts of the 1960s and the present day, enabling learners to develop a detailed understanding of how they appear in mainstream news media and its associated social and participatory media.

The historical front covers are significant in terms of the Media Theoretical Framework as they illustrate a distinct use of media language to construct representations based upon the relevant contexts of the mid to late 1960s in the UK. The media language used to construct representations in the 1960s front covers is representative of UK National broadsheets of the time, of which *The Observer* was a significant and, at the time, independent national newspaper.

It is recommended that learners investigate other similar media products from these periods to reinforce their understanding of how these products reflect their contexts.

Media Language and Representations

Media Form	Set Product	Guidance on selection of set products
<i>The Observer</i> contemporary newspaper covers	Two front covers from <i>The Observer</i> selected by the centre.	Covers chosen must be from editions from the September onwards of the first year of teaching a two-year course.

Teachers are also encouraged to show examples of other covers of their own choice to exemplify contrasting contexts and use of media language and representations.

The following indicative lists for media language and representations are given as guidance and are not exhaustive.

For example, in relation to **media language**, learners must consider:

- the various forms of media language used to create and communicate meaning on newspaper front covers
- how selection, combination and exclusion of elements of media language can influence meaning on newspaper covers
- the relationship between technology and media language on newspaper covers, for example, to aid layout, typography and post-production editing of photos

- the codes and conventions of newspaper covers.

For example, in relation to **media representations**, learners must consider:

- the ways in which newspaper producers re-present the world and construct versions of reality on newspaper covers
- how the purposes of media producers and the choices they make influence representations
- the social, cultural and political significance of particular representations featured on newspaper covers in terms of the themes or issues they address
- how representations reflect the contexts in which they were produced.

Media Industries

Learners must have knowledge and understanding of *The Observer* as a contemporary media product in terms of the relevant newspaper industry issues it illustrates. In order to develop this awareness, learners must consider **one** complete print edition of *The Observer* selected for study from the September onwards of the first year of teaching a two-year course. For example, from September 2017 onwards for a candidate entering for assessment in June 2019.

The following indicative list for media industries is given as guidance and is not exhaustive.

For example, in relation to **media industries**, learners must consider:

- the nature and scope of newspaper production by large organisations, including issues of ownership, control and funding
- the impact of production processes, personnel and technologies on newspaper production
- the increasingly convergent nature of media industries across different platforms, for example, print, online and social and participatory
- the functions of types of regulation of contemporary print newspapers.

In Component 02, learners will develop knowledge and understanding of the following subject content in relation to the relevant set media products:

Topic	Key idea	Learners must demonstrate and apply their knowledge and understanding of:
Media industries	Media producers	the nature of media production, including by large organisations, who own the products they produce, and by individuals and groups.
	The impact of media producers	the impact of production processes, personnel and technologies on the final product, including similarities and differences between media products in terms of when and where they are produced.
	Ownership and control	the effect of ownership and control of media organisations, including conglomerate ownership, diversification and vertical integration.
	Convergence	the impact of the increasingly convergent nature of media industries across different platforms and different national settings.
	Funding	the importance of different funding models, including government funded, not-for-profit and commercial models.
	Globalised audiences	how the media operate as commercial industries on a global scale and reach both large and specialised audiences.
	Media regulation	the functions and types of regulation of the media.
	Regulation and digital media	the challenges for media regulation presented by 'new' digital technologies.
Media language	Media language elements	- the various forms of media language used to create and communicate meanings in media products - fundamental principles of semiotic analysis, including denotation and connotation.
	Media language and meaning	how choice (selection, combination and exclusion) of elements of media language influences meaning in media products, including to create narratives, to portray aspects of reality, to construct points of view, and to represent the world in ways that convey messages and values.

Topic	Key idea	Learners must demonstrate and apply their knowledge and understanding of:
	Technology and media language	the relationship between technology and media products.
	Generic conventions	- the codes and conventions of media language, how they develop and become established as 'styles' or genres (which are common across different media products) and how they may also vary over time - theoretical perspectives on genre, including principles of repetition and variation; the dynamic nature of genre; hybridity and intertextuality.
	Intertextuality	intertextuality, including how inter-relationships between different media products can influence meaning.
Media representations	Mediation	- the ways in which the media re-present (rather than simply present) the world, and construct versions of reality - the choices media producers make about how to represent particular events, social groups and ideas - the ways aspects of reality may be represented differently depending on the purposes of the producers - theoretical perspectives on representation, including processes of selection, construction and mediation.
	Stereotypes	the different functions and uses of stereotypes, including an understanding of how stereotypes become established, how they may vary over time, and how stereotypes enable audiences to interpret media quickly.
	Inequality in representation	- how and why particular social groups may be under-represented or misrepresented - theoretical perspectives on gender and representation, including feminist approaches.
	Themes and ideologies	- how representations (including self-representations) convey particular viewpoints, messages, values and beliefs, which may be reinforced across a wide range of media products - the social, cultural and political significance of particular representations in terms of the themes or issues that they address - theoretical perspectives on gender and representation, including feminist approaches.
	Representation and context	how representations reflect the social, historical and cultural contexts in which they were produced.
	Representation and audience	the factors affecting audience interpretations of representations, including their own experiences and beliefs.

Topic	Key idea	Learners must demonstrate and apply their knowledge and understanding of:
Media audiences	Target audience	• how and why media products are aimed at a range of audiences, from small, specialised audiences to large mass audiences • how media organisations categorise audiences.
	Marketing	• the ways in which media organisations target audiences through marketing, including an understanding of the assumptions organisations make about their target audience(s).
	Technologies	• the role of media technologies in reaching and identifying audiences, and in audience consumption and usage.
	Active audiences	• the ways in which audiences may interpret the same media products very differently and how these differences may reflect both social and individual differences • theoretical perspectives on audiences, including active and passive audiences; audience response and audience interpretation.
	Uses and gratifications	• the social, cultural and political significance of media products, including the themes or issues they address, the fulfilment of needs and desires, and the functions they serve in everyday life and society • the ways in which people's media practices are connected to their identity, including their sense of actual and desired self • Blumler and Katz's Uses and Gratifications theory.
	Changing audience responses	• how audiences may respond to and interpret media products and why these responses and interpretations may change over time.
Contexts	Social	• how media products reflect the society in which they are produced and that of their target audience.
	Cultural	• how media products reflect the arts and culture, including popular culture, of their time.
	Historical	• how media products reflect historical events and social changes.
	Political	• how media products reflect political viewpoints, messages, values and beliefs.